Linux Commands

Permissions, Users and Groups

Why "Permission denied" happens, and what to do about it.

Bhuvnesh Verma

github.com/MasterBhuvnesh/notebooks

Contents

1. File Permissions

In Linux, **permissions (modes)** control who can **read, write, or execute** a file or directory.
When you use:

```
mkdir -m 755 myapp
```

the `755` is the **permission mode** assigned to the directory.

1.1 Permission Types

There are three permission bits:

Permission	Symbol	Value
Read	`r`	4
Write	`w`	2
Execute	`x`	1

The values are added together:

Permission Set	Calculation	Value
`---`	0	0
`--x`	1	1
`-w-`	2	2
`-wx`	2+1	3
`r--`	4	4
`r-x`	4+1	5
`rw-`	4+2	6
`rwx`	4+2+1	7

1.2 Who Gets Permissions?

Linux divides users into three groups:

Group	Meaning
User (`u`)	Owner of the file
Group (`g`)	Users in the file's group
Others (`o`)	Everyone else

A permission like `755` means:

```
7   5   5
|   |   |
|   |   +-- Others
|   +------ Group
+---------- Owner
```

1.3 Example: 755

Break it down:

```
7 = rwx = 4+2+1
5 = r-x = 4+1
5 = r-x = 4+1
```

Result: `rwxr-xr-x`. Meaning:

User Type	Permissions
Owner	Read, Write, Execute
Group	Read, Execute
Others	Read, Execute

1.4 Example: 700

```
7 = rwx
0 = ---
0 = ---
```

Result: `rwx------`. Only the owner can access it. Useful for:

```
mkdir -m 700 secrets
```

1.5 Example: 777

Result: `rwxrwxrwx`. Everyone can read, write and execute.

Warning: Usually avoided, because anyone can modify the contents.

1.6 Example: 644

Common for files.

```
6 = rw-
4 = r--
4 = r--
```

Result: `rw-r--r--`. The owner can read and write; everyone else can only read.

1.7 What Does Execute Mean for a Directory?

For a **file**, `x` means the file can be run as a program or script. For a **directory**, `x` means you can enter it, that is `cd` into it.

```
chmod 600 mydir
```

That gives `rw-------`. You can see the directory, but you **cannot** `cd` into it, because execute permission is missing. To enter a directory, `x` permission is required.

1.8 Viewing Permissions

```
ls -l
```

Example output:

```
drwxr-xr-x 2 bhuvnesh users 4096 Aug 15 project
```

Breakdown:

```
d rwx r-x r-x
| |   |   |
| |   |   +-- Others
```

```
| |   +------ Group
| +---------- Owner
+------------ Directory
```

1.9 Changing Permissions

Numeric method:

```
chmod 755 project
chmod 700 secrets
chmod 644 file.txt
```

Symbolic method:

```
chmod u+x script.sh   # add execute permission for the owner
chmod g+w file.txt    # add write permission for the group
chmod o-r file.txt    # remove read permission for others
```

1.10 Common Modes You Will Use

Mode	Meaning	Typical Use
755	`rwxr-xr-x`	Application directories
700	`rwx------`	Private directories
644	`rw-r--r--`	Regular files
600	`rw-------`	Secrets, keys, passwords
777	`rwxrwxrwx`	Rarely recommended

Real-world examples

```
mkdir -m 755 backend
mkdir -m 700 .ssh
touch app.js
chmod 644 app.js
chmod 600 id_rsa
```

For software development you will most often see:

- **Directories:** `755`
- **Source code files:** `644`
- **Shell scripts:** `755`
- **SSH private keys and `.env` files:** `600` or `400`

2. Users, Groups and Ownership

To really understand Linux permissions, you need to understand **users**, **groups** and **ownership** first. Linux is a multi-user operating system. On a company server:

```
ubuntu
+-- bhuvnesh
+-- rohan
+-- alice
+-- john
```

Each person has their own account.

2.1 Viewing the Current User

```
whoami
# bhuvnesh

id
# uid=1000(bhuvnesh) gid=1000(bhuvnesh) groups=1000(bhuvnesh),27(sudo)
```

- UID = User ID
- GID = Group ID
- Groups = the groups this user belongs to

2.2 What is a User?

A user is an account that can log in, own files, run processes and hold permissions.

```
sudo useradd john     # create a user
sudo passwd john      # set the password
```

2.3 What is a Group?

A group is a collection of users.

```
developers
+-- bhuvnesh
+-- rohan
+-- alice
```

Instead of assigning permissions to each user, assign them to the group.

2.4 Managing Groups

```
sudo groupadd developers          # create a group
cat /etc/group                    # check it exists

sudo usermod -aG developers john  # add a user (-a append, -G group)
groups john
# john : john developers

sudo gpasswd -d john developers   # remove a user from the group
sudo groupdel developers          # delete the group
```

2.5 Deleting a User

```
sudo userdel john      # delete the user
sudo userdel -r john   # delete the user and their home directory
```

2.6 Where Users Are Stored

Linux stores users in `/etc/passwd`:

```
cat /etc/passwd
```

```
john:x:1001:1001::/home/john:/bin/bash
```

The fields are: username, password placeholder, UID, GID, comment, home directory, shell.

2.7 Where Passwords Are Stored

```
sudo cat /etc/shadow
```

Only root can read it. It contains hashed passwords.

2.8 What is Root?

Linux has a superuser called `root`. Root can create and delete users, modify any file, install software and shut the server down.

```
sudo su
# or
su -

whoami
# root
```

2.9 Ownership of Files

```
touch app.js
ls -l
# -rw-r--r-- 1 bhuvnesh developers 0 Aug 15 app.js
```

Here the owner is `bhuvnesh` and the group is `developers`.

```
sudo chown john app.js              # change the owner
sudo chgrp developers app.js        # change the group
sudo chown john:developers app.js   # change both at once
```

2.10 Directory Permissions Example

```
mkdir project
chmod 770 project
```

With owner `bhuvnesh` and group `developers`, `770` means `rwxrwx---`:

Who	Access
Owner	Full
Group	Full
Others	None

So anyone in `developers` can use the directory.

2.11 Real Company Example

```
developers          designers
+-- bhuvnesh        +-- john
+-- rohan           +-- sara
+-- alice
```

Create a shared directory:

```
sudo mkdir /shared-code
sudo chown root:developers /shared-code
sudo chmod 770 /shared-code
```

Developers can access it; designers cannot.

2.12 Sudo Access

Not every user can become root. On Ubuntu, users allowed to run `sudo` belong to the `sudo` group.

```
groups bhuvnesh
# bhuvnesh sudo

sudo usermod -aG sudo john   # now john can run: sudo apt update
```

2.13 System Users vs Human Users

Listing `/etc/passwd` shows entries like `root`, `daemon`, `www-data`, `mysql`, `postgres`, `nginx`, `ubuntu` and `bhuvnesh`. Not all of them are humans.

User	Purpose
`root`	Administrator
`mysql`	MySQL service
`postgres`	PostgreSQL service
`nginx`	Nginx server
`www-data`	Apache / Nginx web apps

These are called **service accounts**.

2.14 Process Ownership

Every running process belongs to a user.

```
ps aux
```

```
USER      PID
root      123
postgres  456
nginx     789
```

PostgreSQL runs as `postgres` and Nginx runs as `nginx`. This improves security.

2.15 Useful Admin Commands

Command	Description	Example
`useradd`	Create a user, with a home directory	`sudo useradd -m john`
`passwd`	Set a user's password	`sudo passwd john`
`groupadd`	Create a group	`sudo groupadd developers`
`usermod`	Add a user to a group	`sudo usermod -aG developers john`
`chown`	Change the owner of a file	`sudo chown john file.txt`
`chgrp`	Change the group of a file	`sudo chgrp developers file.txt`
`userdel`	Delete a user and their home directory	`sudo userdel -r john`
`groupdel`	Delete a group	`sudo groupdel developers`
`whoami`	Show the current user	`whoami`
`id`	Show user and group IDs	`id`

2.16 How This Applies to Docker, Nginx and PostgreSQL

When you run `docker run nginx`, Nginx inside the container often runs as `nginx`, not `root`. When PostgreSQL starts, `postgres` owns the database files. When GitHub Actions deploys code, `ubuntu` or a dedicated deployment user may own the files.

Understanding **users, groups, ownership and permissions** is one of the most important Linux concepts, because it explains why commands sometimes fail with:

```
Permission denied
```

Most of the time the current user is not the owner, is not in the required group, or lacks the necessary permission bits (`r`, `w`, `x`).